confidence that if Israel succeeded in prolonging the withdrawal and holding on to Gaza and Sharm for two or three more weeks, then the public diplomacy efforts in the United States, both within the administration and among the American public, would inevitably bear fruit.

During a cabinet meeting, a discussion was opened in which unanimity was expressed regarding the military necessity to control Gaza. On the other hand, there were grave doubts regarding Israel's ability to assume responsibility for the refugees in the city. When Interior Minister Haim Moshe Shapira, the leader of the National Religious Party, said, "I am very anxious about the prospect of 250,000 Arabs being added to the State of Israel. What would that mean?" Ben-Gurion interjected, "In the present circumstances of the political regime in Israel, this would mean Arab rule of the country!"

When the ministers asked Ben-Gurion to elaborate, he said the following:

> I am strongly opposed to the demilitarization of Sinai [a proposal raised by Minister Shapira]—this will only strengthen Nasser's position against demilitarization. I reject here and now the declaration that we will be prepared to take responsibility for some of the refugees, the reason being that we do not know where we will settle them. In Gaza today we are already feeding them, providing medical assistance, and establishing municipalities, and the residents themselves, not only the refugees, are destitute and in need of our help. Therefore, it is not advisable to rush to commit to doing more than that. In Israel's existing regime of twenty parties, the Arabs will control us. There are all kinds of ideas. For example, Ezra Danin thinks we can offer the Christian Arabs financial compensation and send them, with their consent, to Argentina, but I am not sure if this is possible. Some say that we can settle a small portion of the refugees in El-Arish, which is a possibility, but not before experts examine this idea and come back to us with a well-founded opinion. Some say that it is possible to bring a thousand Arabs into Jaffa, and it is worth examining this idea. In any event, we cannot just commit ourselves to absorbing 300,000 Arabs from Gaza—it's still early.

Toward the end of the meeting, Prime Minister and Defense Minister Ben-Gurion proposed announcing a series of actions already being carried out in Gaza to benefit its residents and the refugees. His proposal was accepted, and at a later meeting held that day it was decided to announce the following:

We decide:

1. To renew the activities of the local authorities in Gaza and elsewhere in the Gaza Strip.